

Academic Writing & Assignment

Week 3: Lesson 2



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

- Yesterday, we looked at essay structures and topic sentences
- Read the sample essay. Highlight:
 - The thesis statement in the introduction
 - The thesis statement in the conclusion
 - The topic sentences
- Are the topic sentences effective? Why/Why not?
- Is the structure of the essay clear? Why/Why not?

- Today, we are going to focus on cohesion
- Cohesion links the ideas of your essay together and makes them flow better.
- Read the sample essay and identify cohesive devices.

Cohesive devices you may have noticed:



- Linking words
- This/These/Such + Noun



Linking words



Linking words



The essay contains a wide range of linking words and expressions. List them in the table on the other page.



Add the linking words from the essay



Addition and continuation	Contrast and concession	Example and specification	Emphasis and stance	Result, cause and logical development	Sequencing and structure

Add the linking words from the essay



Addition and continuation	Contrast and concession	Example and specification	Emphasis and stance	Result, cause and logical development	Sequencing and structure
Moreover Furthermore In addition At the same time Similarly including	However rather than whereas while Although Nevertheless On the one hand On the other hand Rather despite but although Instead of	For example In particular in some cases In other words By the same logic	Importantly Significantly Ultimately In this respect From this perspective	Consequently As a result because Because If...then but that Accordingly Taken together	At the outset To support this argument then and finally First Second Instead

What is the aim of the following linking words?



Sentence	Cohesive Device	Function
The figure, however, describes reach rather than effect.	However	Contrast
Consequently, the sheer scale of social media adoption can make relatively small individual harms appear to constitute a major societal problem.		
In other words, causality appears to operate in both directions.		
As a result, the overall average was close to zero.		
Accordingly, the key questions become not how many people use social media, but which users experience harm.		
At the same time, users' beliefs about social media appear to play a significant role.		

What is the aim of the following linking words?



Sentence	Cohesive Device	Function
The figure, <u>however</u> , describes reach rather than effect.	However	Contrast
<u>Consequently</u> , the sheer scale of social media adoption can make relatively small individual harms appear to constitute a major societal problem.	Consequently	Result
<u>In other words</u> , causality appears to operate in both directions.	In other words	Restatement
<u>As a result</u> , the overall average was close to zero.	As a result	Result
<u>Accordingly</u> , the key questions become not how many people use social media, but which users experience harm.	Accordingly	Logical conclusion
<u>At the same time</u> , users' beliefs about social media appear to play a significant role.	At the same time	Addition/ Shift of focus

Some common errors with linking words:



1. Besides
2. Punctuation
3. Despite
4. On the contrary
5. Overuse

- ‘Besides’ is not exactly the same as ‘and’ or ‘in addition
- We use ‘besides’ to add an idea as an afterthought– to add a piece of information that we thought of while we were speaking/writing.
- For example: “I can’t go out tonight, because I’ve got work in the morning... besides, I haven’t been sleeping well and I’m exhausted.”
- It’s best avoided in academic writing.

Punctuation: which sentences are correct?



1. Many governments have introduced policies to encourage larger families, however the evidence regarding their long-term effectiveness remains mixed.



2. Many governments have introduced policies to encourage larger families. However, the evidence regarding their long-term effectiveness remains mixed.



3. Many governments have introduced policies to encourage larger families; however, the evidence regarding their long-term effectiveness remains mixed.



Which sentences are correct?



1. Despite declining birth rates, the country's population has continued to grow due to immigration. ✓
2. Despite government efforts to increase fertility, birth rates remain below replacement level. ✓
3. Despite the birth rate has declined, the population is still growing. ✗
4. Despite of an ageing population, economic growth has remained stable. ✗
5. The proportion of older adults is increasing. Despite this trend, public spending on elderly care has not risen significantly. ✓

'In contrast' or 'On the contrary'?



1. Some people believe that population ageing will reduce economic growth. _____, others argue that older workers can continue to contribute productively for many years.
2. Rural areas in the country are losing population. _____, major cities are growing rapidly.
3. Immigration has not depressed wages in the region. _____, it has filled labour shortages in sectors that employers struggled to staff.
4. The birth rate in South Korea remains very low. _____, several African countries continue to experience high fertility rates.
5. Rising life expectancy does not automatically mean more years of good health. _____, many countries are seeing a longer period of illness before death.

‘In contrast’ or ‘On the contrary’?



1. Some people believe that population ageing will reduce economic growth. **In contrast**, others argue that older workers can continue to contribute productively for many years.
2. Rural areas in the country are losing population. **In contrast**, major cities are growing rapidly.
3. Immigration has not depressed wages in the region. **On the contrary**, it has filled labour shortages in sectors that employers struggled to staff.
4. The birth rate in South Korea remains very low. **In contrast**, several African countries continue to experience high fertility rates.
5. Rising life expectancy does not automatically mean more years of good health. **On the contrary**, many countries are seeing a longer period of illness before death.

Sometimes cohesive devices are overused.
Reduce the number in this paragraph:



Firstly, sub-Saharan Africa is the only world region where the population is projected to continue growing rapidly throughout this century. Secondly, the median age in the region is currently under 20. Moreover, this young age structure creates the potential for a demographic dividend. However, in addition, the dividend is not automatic. Therefore, governments must expand secondary education and create formal-sector employment at a pace few countries have achieved. In conclusion, the outcome depends on policy rather than on demography alone.

This/These/Such + Noun



The essay contains many reference words e.g.



The fact that 3.96 billion people use social media is often presented as alarming. **This figure** reflects the scale of adoption rather than the nature of its effects.

This figure = _____

Distress is most common among users who feel they have lost control of their social media use. **This finding** suggests that perceptions are an important part of the experience.

This finding = _____

Find other examples and say what they refer to:



Reference	What it refers to
this perspective	
such concerns	
these anxieties	
this represents a minority	
this same emphasis	
this evidence	
those outcomes	
these outcomes	
these processes	
such a comparison	

Find other examples and say what they refer to:



Reference	What it refers to
this perspective	the view that concern should focus on particular practices and features
such concerns	worries about depression, anxiety and problematic device use
these anxieties	the public and parental concerns just described
this represents a minority	approximately one-fifth of respondents
this same emphasis	treating the number of users as evidence of a problem
this evidence	the studies and meta-analyses discussed in the paragraph
those outcomes	users' different experiences and effects
these outcomes	cyberbullying, trolling, outrage, dehumanisation and division
these processes	the harmful forms of online interaction described previously
such a comparison	social media to the printing press

Complete the gap with *this / these / such a* + noun



assumption
caveat
constraint
decline
discrepancy

inconsistency
mechanism
phenomenon

trade-off

trend

1. Fertility in Iran fell from about 6.5 births per woman in 1980 to below replacement level within thirty years. Demographers continue to debate the causes of _____.
2. The government's forecast assumes that net migration will remain at present

Complete the gap with *this / these / such a* + noun



assumption
caveat
constraint
decline
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mechanism
phenomenon

trade-off

trend

5. Households in high-income countries are becoming smaller, later-forming and more likely to consist of a single person. _____ is now observable across almost all OECD members.

Possible Answers



1. Fertility in Iran fell from about 6.5 births per woman in 1980 to below replacement level within thirty years. Demographers continue to debate the causes of [this decline/shift/trend](#).
2. The government's forecast assumes that net migration will remain at present levels. [This assumption](#) is unlikely to hold if border policy changes after the election.
3. Census data provide valuable insights into demographic change; however, some groups are underrepresented in official statistics. This [caveat](#) limits the reliability of certain population estimates.
4. Some studies report a negative effect of population ageing on productivity; others find none. [This discrepancy/inconsistency](#) may reflect differences in how productivity is measured.
5. Households in high-income countries are becoming smaller, later-forming and more likely to consist of a single person. [This tendency/shift/phenomenon/trend](#) is now observable across almost all OECD members.
6. The model treats the working-age population as everyone between 15 and 64. [This constraint/definition](#) excludes students in tertiary education and understates the dependent population.
7. Raising the retirement age reduces pension expenditure, but it also delays the entry of younger workers into senior roles. Any credible reform must confront [this trade-off](#).

Parallel Structures



Parallelism



Policymakers should focus on identifying who is harmed, by what mechanisms, and under what conditions.

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Identify the best sentence



- A: Governments are trying to increase birth rates, support families, and improving childcare provision.
- B: Governments are trying to increase birth rates, support families, and improve childcare provision.
- A: Population decline may reduce economic growth, increase labour shortages, and weaken tax revenues.
- B: Population decline may reduce economic growth, increasing labour shortages, and tax revenues become weaker.
- A: Policymakers must decide whether to encourage immigration, raise the retirement age, or increasing fertility rates.
- B: Policymakers must decide whether to encourage immigration, raise the retirement age, or increase fertility rates.

Improve the parallelism in this paragraph



Population ageing is creating several challenges for governments. It can increase healthcare costs, workers become less available, and there is more pressure on pension systems. In response, governments may invest in healthcare services, supporting older workers, and they might encourage immigration.

Lexical Chains



A lexical chain is a series of words and phrases that refer to the same idea throughout a text.

For example:

Population ageing → this demographic trend → an ageing population → older societies → the increase in the proportion of elderly citizens

Using lexical chains helps writers avoid repetition while keeping the topic clear.

Read the paragraph and identify 2 lexical chains:



Population ageing has become a major concern in many developed countries. This demographic trend is increasing pressure on healthcare systems and pension schemes. As older societies continue to grow, governments face difficult decisions about public spending. The rising proportion of elderly citizens is therefore becoming an increasingly important policy issue.

Read the paragraph and identify 2 lexical chains:



Population ageing has become a major concern in many developed countries. This demographic trend is increasing pressure on healthcare systems and pension schemes. As older societies continue to grow, governments face difficult decisions about public spending. The rising proportion of elderly citizens is therefore becoming an increasingly important policy issue.

Which version has better cohesion and why?



- **Version A:** Fertility rates have declined in many countries. Fertility rates are causing concern among policymakers. Fertility rates may affect economic growth. Fertility rates may influence the future size of the workforce.
- **Version B:** Fertility rates have declined in many countries. This demographic trend is causing concern among policymakers because lower birth rates may affect economic growth and reduce the future size of the workforce.

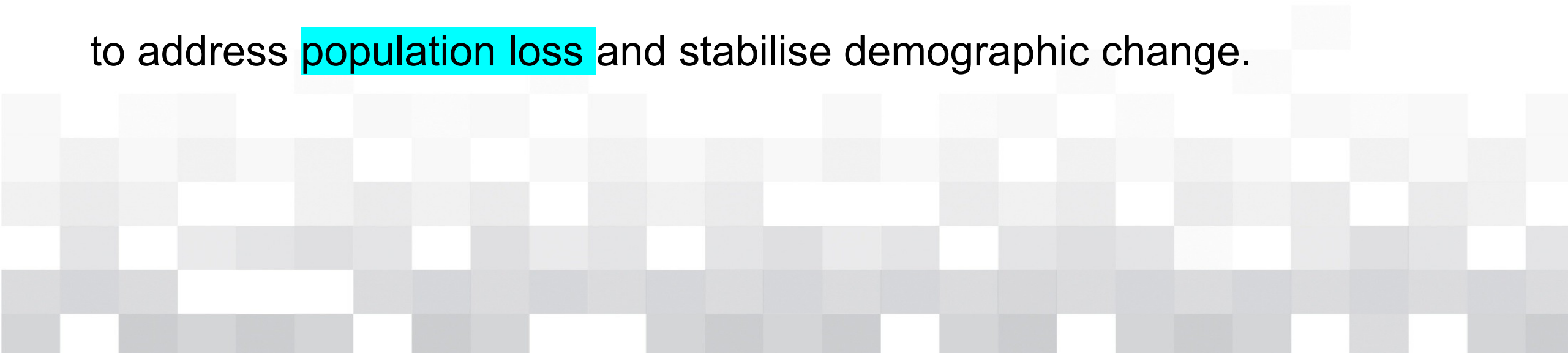
Improve this paragraph



Population decline is affecting many regions. Population decline has created labour shortages. Population decline is increasing concern among governments. Population decline may affect long-term economic growth.

Useful language: this demographic trend, shrinking populations, declining population levels, these demographic changes, population loss

Population decline is affecting many regions. This demographic trend has created labour shortages and increased concern among governments. Shrinking populations may also have consequences for long-term economic growth. As a result, policymakers are seeking ways to address population loss and stabilise demographic change.

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Repetition



In academic writing, lexical chains improve cohesion. However, some key terms should be repeated because synonyms can be inaccurate, vague, or misleading.



Which is better and why?



- A: Fertility rates have fallen significantly across many developed countries. This decline in fertility rates has led governments to reconsider family policies.
- B: Fertility rates have fallen significantly across many developed countries. This decline in child production has led governments to reconsider family policies.
- A: Population ageing is increasing pressure on pension systems. Population ageing is also creating challenges for healthcare services.
- B: Population ageing is increasing pressure on pension systems. This demographic trend is also creating challenges for healthcare services.
- A: Immigration has become a major contributor to population growth. Immigration has also helped address labour shortages.
- B: Immigration has become a major contributor to population growth. The movement of people across borders has also helped address labour shortages.
- A: Fertility rates affect the size of future populations. Fertility rates also influence the age structure of societies.
- B: Fertility rates affect the size of future populations. They also influence the age structure of societies.

The writer has tried to avoid repetition. Some changes improve the text, while others make it worse. Underline the expression that should be changed back to the original term



Population ageing has become a major issue for many governments. This demographic trend is expected to continue in the coming decades. However, the increase in older people is not affecting all countries equally. In some regions, the greying phenomenon has created significant labour shortages. Policymakers are therefore attempting to respond to this silver challenge through pension reform and immigration policies.

Tasks



Task: Add cohesive devices to improve this paragraph



Urban planners argue that rapid urbanization creates serious problems for cities in developing countries. There are many reasons why rapid urbanization creates problems for cities in developing countries, such as the fact that rapid urbanization puts pressure on housing. Rapid urbanization also puts pressure on public transport. Also, rapid urbanization increases demand for clean water and increases demand for sanitation. Rapid urbanization also leads to the growth of informal settlements, and the growth of informal settlements means that city governments cannot provide services to everyone. Rapid urbanization is also usually not matched by the creation of formal jobs. Finally, rapid urbanization also often causes an increase in air pollution.

Follow-on task:



- Look at the essay you wrote on Friday.
- What cohesive devices does it contain?
- Can you improve cohesion?